

Indian Household Food Byproducts & Upcycling Guide

A Reference Matrix for Zero-Waste Community Kitchens, Chefs, and Home Cooks

1. VEGETABLE PEELS & SKINS (CHILKA / KHOSHA / THOL)

Household Scrap	Regional Names	Traditional Upcycling Method
Bottle Gourd Peels	Lauki Chilka, Lau-er Khosha, Sorakkay Thol	Stir-fried crisp with nigella seeds (Chechki / Bhaja), ground with roasted peanuts for chutney, or mixed into raita.
Ridge Gourd Peels	Turai Chilka, Jhinge Khosha, Peer kangai Thol	Coarsely roasted with urad dal, dried red chillies, and tamarind into Thogayal / Chutney / Bata.
Potato Peels	Aloo Chilka, Aloo Khosha, Urulaikizhangu Thol	Shallow-fried with poppy seeds (Posto Aloo Khosha Bhaja) or seasoned with chaat masala into crispy chips.
Raw Banana / Plantain Peels	Kacche Kele Ka Chilka, Kancha Kolar Khosha, Vazhakkai Thol	Boiled and mashed with mustard oil, garlic, and green chillies into Khosha Bata, or stir-fried into Kerala Thoran.
Pointed Gourd Peels	Parwal Chilka, Potal Khosha	Ground into a spicy paste with mustard paste, garlic, and green chillies (Potal Khosha Bata).
Pumpkin Peels & Fibers	Kaddu Chilka, Kumro Khosha, Parangikai Thol	Pan-roasted crisp with turmeric and cumin seeds, or slow-cooked into mixed-vegetable curries (Labra / Sambhar).
Bitter Gourd Peels	Karela Chilka, Korola Khosha, Pavakkai Thol	Salted to extract excess bitterness, mixed with besan (gram flour), and fried into crunchy, blood-sugar friendly fritters.
Carrot & Radish Skins	Gajar/Mooli Chilka, Mulo Khosha	Sautéed into quick dry subzis with mustard seeds or blended into mixed-peel chutneys.
Eggplant / Brinjal Peels	Baingan Chilka, Begun Khosha, Kathirikai Thol	Simmered in tangy yogurt/mustard gravies (e.g., Kashmiri Khatte Baingan peel curry).

2. STEMS, STALKS & GREEN LEAVES (DANTA / THANDU / LEAVES)

Household Scrap	Regional Names	Traditional Upcycling Method
Cauliflower Stems & Green Ribs	Phool Gobi Danthal, Fulkopi Danta, Cauliflower Thandu	Peeled and simmered into mustard paste gravies (Danta Chorchori), stir-fries with potatoes, or crunchy winter pickles.
Coriander & Mint Stems	Dhaniya Dandi, Dhonepata Danta, Kothamalli Thandu	Rich in volatile essential oils; blended into restaurant-style green chutney, soup bases, and marinades.
Broccoli Stalks	Broccoli Danthal	Woody exterior peeled away, core julienned into stir-fries, grated for paratha fillings, or pureed into soups.
Beetroot & Radish Greens	Chukandar / Mooli ke Patte, Mulo Saag	Finely chopped and cooked with garlic and green chillies into dry saag (Mooli Patte ki Sabzi).
Colocasia / Taro Stems & Leaves	Arbi ke Patte / Dandi, Kochur Saag, Chembu Ila	Steamed with spiced besan into pinwheel rolls (Patra / Patrode) or cooked with coconut-mustard paste.
Cabbage Outer Tough Leaves & Core	Patta Gobi ki Dandi	Shredded fine for quick stir-fried bhurji or slow-simmered in hearty vegetable broths.

3. SEEDS, PITHS & RINDS (BEEJ / BICHI / GUTHLI)

Household Scrap	Regional Names	Traditional Upcycling Method
Watermelon White Rind	<i>Tarbooj ka Safed Chilka, Tarmooj Khosha</i>	Diced and made into soft morning dosas (Kalingana Polo), sweet halwa/murabba, or savory spiced gravies.
Jackfruit Seeds	<i>Kathal ke Beej, Enchorer Bichi, Palakottai</i>	Dried, boiled, and cooked in thick lentil dals, roasted over open charcoal embers, or stewed in spicy gravies.
Pumpkin Seeds	<i>Kaddu ke Beej, Kumror Bichi</i>	Washed, sun-dried, and dry-roasted with black salt and cumin as a nutrient-dense zinc snack.
Raw Mango Pits & Skins	<i>Aam ki Guthli, Aam Aantti, Maangai Kottai</i>	Simmered inside summer rasams or dals for natural acidity, or dried into tangy dry aamchur pickles.
Squeezed Lemon / Lime Halves	<i>Nichoda Hua Nimbu, Lebur Khosha</i>	Stuffed with salt and turmeric, sun-cured in glass jars for 3 weeks into zero-waste probiotic lemon pickle.

4. GRAINS, STARCHES & LEFTOVER STAPLES (BASI / LEFTOVER)

Household Scrap	Regional Names	Traditional Upcycling Method
Leftover Cooked Rice	<i>Basi Bhaat, Pazhaya Saadham, Panta Bhaat</i>	Soaked overnight in water with green chillies for fermented breakfast, or mashed into crispy rice pakoras.
Stale Rotis / Chapati Ends	<i>Basi Roti, Pazhaya Roti</i>	Torn into pieces and tempered with mustard seeds, onions, and curry leaves (Roti Poha / Seyal Phulka / Kutti Roti).
Stale Bread Crusts & Ends	<i>Bread ke Kinare</i>	Toasted dry and pulsed into homemade breadcrumbs, or prepared as spicy bread upma and shahi tukda bites.
Rice Wash Water	<i>Chawal ka Paani, Dhowa Jal, Arisi Kalainja Thanneer</i>	Used as a nutrient-rich cooking broth for dal, kneading soft roti dough, or as a mineral-rich soup base.
Cooked Rice Starch Water	<i>Maanrh, Kanji Thanneer, Ganji</i>	Seasoned with rock salt and roasted cumin as an energizing hydration tonic, or used as a gravy thickener.

5. DAIRY & SPICE DISCARDS

Household Scrap	Regional Names	Traditional Upcycling Method
Paneer / Chhena Whey Water	<i>Paneer ka Paani, Chhanar Jal</i>	High in complete protein; used to knead chapati dough, boil lentils, or form the liquid base of curries.
Sour Curd / Leftover Dahi	<i>Khatta Dahi, Tok Doi, Puliya Thayir</i>	Whisked with besan to make traditional Kadhi, rava dhokla fermenter, or South Indian Mor Kuzhambu.
Browned Ghee Sediment Residue	<i>Mawa / Berukho / Khurchan / Mor Kali</i>	Caramelized milk solids remaining in pan; tossed with hot rice and jaggery/sugar, or rolled into quick pedas.
Peeled Ginger Skins	<i>Adrak ka Chilka, Ada-r Khosha, Inji Thol</i>	Washed and dried, dropped directly into morning chai pots or boiled into immunity tisanes (kadha).
Coconut Brown Husk Skins	<i>Nariyal ka Khurchan / Brown Skin</i>	Shredded and dry-roasted with red chillies, tamarind, and garlic into flavorful dry idli podi.